Company was variously commanded by Maj SBS Rana, AK Pundir and SK Pandey.

The foremost terrorist 'leader' in this area was a young lad named Mustafa Khan, hailing from the village of Goigam in the AOR of Malamu COB. He had the image of part *goonda* (thug), part Robin Hood. Such was his writ that the entire swath South of the Narabal–Magam road would follow his diktats. Since he and his gang of four to six terrorists would only move at night, he had passed 'orders' that all villages would have a curfew from dusk to dawn. Such was the fear factor that this diktat was followed without a murmur. Anyone not toeing the line would be considered a *mukhbir*, an informer, and summarily shot. Nobody was spared, not even women or children. Obviously, this was not a situation that could be allowed to continue. The very purpose of our deployment was to create conditions of normalcy and this state of affairs was nothing but outright terrorism, of forcing an entire population into submission at gunpoint. Apprehending Mustafa Khan became the priority for the Battalion. Every scrap of information was fed into a database: friends and relatives, girlfriends and class fellows, known associates, last known location and activity (intimidation, extortion, grenade-throwing, killing, etc.). Gradually, an intelligence picture built up.

At last, I felt that we were ready to strike and passed orders for a cordon and search operation targeting two to three most likely hideouts. After the briefing, Capt. Rajeev Bahuguna, commanding the Echo Company COB at Malamu, came to my office along with the 2iC. Rajeev presented his case against launching the operation that night. He had been working hard on catching Mustafa Khan, 'got into his head', so to say. Rajeev was sure that on the coming Friday, he would certainly go to his father's village not only for the Friday prayers but also because

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation